

Moving-In Condition Report & Rights Checklist — ACT

Get this right on day one — it protects your bond for the entire tenancy.

Correct as at July 2026. General information only, not legal advice.

Section 1 — Before You Sign the Lease

- ☐ ☐ **Know your tenancy is governed by the Residential Tenancies Act 1997 (ACT)** and the Residential Tenancies Regulation 1998.
- ☐ ☐ **Ask about heating quality specifically** — given Canberra's cold winters, functioning, efficient heating is a genuine liveability issue worth confirming before you sign, not just a nice-to-have.
- ☐ ☐ **Ask about smoke alarm compliance** and any recent safety checks.

Section 2 — The Condition Report Itself

- ☐ ☐ **Request the entry condition report** if not automatically provided.
- ☐ ☐ **Complete your own section thoroughly**, room by room.
- ☐ ☐ **Photograph everything**, especially existing wear, damage, or imperfections.
- ☐ ☐ **Note existing issues explicitly**.
- ☐ ☐ **Test everything that should work**: taps, toilets, switches, power points, stovetop, heating, and any included appliances.
- ☐ ☐ **Submit your condition report within the required timeframe**.
- ☐ ☐ **Keep a copy for yourself** — you'll need it again at the end of your lease.

Section 3 — Ongoing Rights During Your Tenancy

- ☐ ☐ **Know your rent increase protections**. Increases require at least **8 weeks' written notice**, and **cannot occur within the first 12 months** of your tenancy — genuinely stronger initial protection than several other states.
- ☐ ☐ **Know you can challenge an increase**. If you believe a rent increase is excessive, you can raise this with your landlord and, if unresolved, apply to ACAT.
- ☐ ☐ **Request repairs in writing** — this creates a paper trail if a dispute later needs to go to ACAT.
- ☐ ☐ **Know your bond can't exceed 4 weeks' rent**.

Section 4 — Red Flags at Move-In

- ☐ ☐ **A condition report with suspiciously few noted issues** on an older or clearly lived-in property.
- ☐ ☐ **Being pressured to sign before receiving the condition report or properly inspecting**.
- ☐ ☐ **A property with genuinely inadequate heating** given Canberra's climate — this affects both comfort and, potentially, your ongoing energy costs.

Quick Reference — ACT Tenant Rights & Key Facts

REQUIREMENT	DETAIL
Governing legislation	Residential Tenancies Act 1997 (ACT)
Rent increase notice	8 weeks, none within first 12 months
Maximum bond	4 weeks' rent
Dispute resolution	ACAT (ACT Civil and Administrative Tribunal)

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